

Disaster Recovery Plan

Condensed Study Notes

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DISASTER RECOVERY PLAN

Imagine your home has a plan for what to do if a big storm hits. You know where to go, what to grab, and how to get in touch with people. A Disaster Recovery Plan (DRP) is similar, but for businesses and their important computer systems.

It's like a detailed instruction manual that tells everyone exactly what steps to take to get things back up and running after something bad happens, like a fire, flood, or a major computer problem.

The main goal is to minimize the disruption and get operations back to normal as quickly as possible.

Key ideas:

- A DRP is a set of instructions for dealing with emergencies.
- It helps businesses recover from unexpected events.
- The focus is on getting things working again fast.

How disaster recovery works

We've already talked about a Disaster Recovery Plan (DRP) as a set of instructions for getting things back to normal after a problem. Now, let's look at how these plans actually work by breaking them down into three main types of actions.

Think of preparing for a big storm. You need to know when the storm is coming, what to do to protect your house, and how to fix things if damage happens.

- Detective measures are like having a weather alert system. They help you know *when* something bad is happening, so you can react quickly. They focus on spotting problems as they occur in real-time.
- Corrective measures are like having sandbags ready and knowing how to patch up a leaky roof. These involve planning for what to do if a disaster *does* happen, having backup systems ready to keep things running as smoothly as possible, and having clear steps to get your data and systems back up and running fast.
- Preventive measures are like building your house to withstand strong winds or making sure your plumbing is in good shape to avoid a burst pipe. These are about making your systems as safe and dependable as possible to stop a disaster from happening in the first place. This can involve making copies of important information (backing up data) or constantly checking your systems to make sure they are set up correctly and following all the rules.

What is considered a disaster

We've talked about having a plan to get things back to normal after a problem. Now, let's figure out what kinds of problems are so big they're considered a 'disaster' that would trigger that plan.

Think of a disaster like a really unexpected and disruptive event that messes up your usual way of doing things, especially your business operations.

Disasters can come in many forms:

- **Things from nature:** These are events like earthquakes shaking the ground, floods covering everything, tornadoes ripping through, hurricanes bringing strong winds and rain, or wildfires burning everything up. These are all powerful forces that are beyond human control.
- **Problems with technology:** Sometimes, the very tools we rely on can fail. This could be a simple power outage that shuts everything down, an explosion at a place like a pipeline, or accidents involving transportation that disrupt services. These are issues that arise from the systems and infrastructure we've built.
- **When people get sick on a large scale:** This includes things like pandemics (diseases spreading worldwide) and epidemics (diseases spreading widely in a region). These can cause widespread disruption to people and operations.
- **Attacks on our digital world (Cyber attacks):** This is when bad actors try to break into computer systems. Examples include:
 - **Malware:** This is like a computer virus or a sneaky program designed to harm your computer or steal information.
 - **DDoS attacks:** This stands for Distributed Denial of Service. Imagine thousands of people all trying to call a single phone number at the exact same time – the line gets overloaded and no one can get through. A DDoS attack does this to websites or online services, overwhelming them so legitimate users can't access them.
 - **Ransomware attacks:** This is where attackers lock up your important files or systems and demand money (a ransom) to unlock them.
- **Machines and equipment breaking down (Machine and hardware failure):** Sometimes, the physical parts of your computer systems or other essential machinery just stop working. This can bring operations to a halt.
- **Deliberate harm from people (Other intentional, human-caused threats):** These are disasters caused by people's actions, such as terrorist attacks or biochemical attacks, where dangerous substances are released.

What is a Disaster Recovery Plan

Imagine your business is like a busy restaurant. A Disaster Recovery Plan (DRP) is like a detailed emergency playbook for that restaurant. It's a set of written instructions that tells everyone exactly what to do to get the kitchen back up and running smoothly if something unexpected happens, like a major equipment breakdown or a sudden power outage.

The main goal of this playbook is to help the organization (your restaurant) get back to doing its important work as quickly as possible after a disruption.

Think of 'Disaster Recovery' (DR) as a specific part of that overall playbook. It's all about making sure the essential tools and systems your restaurant needs to operate (like your ovens, refrigerators, and ordering

system – which are like a business's IT infrastructure) can be accessed and used again after a problem occurs.

This DR part is a key piece of a larger plan called 'Business Continuity' (BC). While Business Continuity is about keeping the whole restaurant running, even if in a limited way, Disaster Recovery specifically focuses on getting those critical IT systems back online quickly.

In today's world, especially if your business uses online services (like ordering food through an app or managing inventory in the cloud), having a good DRP is super important. Disasters can happen without any warning, and they can stop services and lead to lost information.

7 Chapters of an IT Disaster Recovery Plan

We've learned that a Disaster Recovery Plan (DRP) is like a detailed instruction manual for a business to get back on its feet after something bad happens to its computer systems. Now, let's look at the typical structure of such a plan.

Think of an IT Disaster Recovery Plan as a comprehensive emergency kit for a business's technology. Just like a well-organized kit has different compartments for different tools, a DRP is usually broken down into several key parts, or 'chapters', to make sure everything is covered. These chapters help organize the steps needed to get the technology working again after a disaster.

While the raw content provided doesn't detail the specific '7 Chapters', a typical IT Disaster Recovery Plan is structured into logical sections to guide the recovery process effectively. These sections usually cover everything from initial assessments to full restoration and testing.

Here is the typical structure of a DR plan

Think of a Disaster Recovery Plan (DRP) like a detailed emergency manual for a business.

This manual is broken down into different chapters, each covering a specific part of getting things back to normal after a problem.

Here's what those chapters usually cover:

1. **Goals:** This is like setting the finish line for your recovery. It includes:

- **Recovery Time Objective (RTO):** This is the maximum amount of time a critical system can be down before it causes too much damage. Imagine it as the maximum time a store can be closed before losing too many customers.
- **Recovery Point Objective (RPO):** This is the maximum amount of data you can afford to lose. Think of it as how much of your daily sales records you're okay with losing if something goes wrong.

2. **Personnel:** This chapter lists the people who are in charge of making the plan happen when a disaster strikes. They are the emergency response team.

3. **IT Inventory:** This is like a detailed catalog of all the computer equipment (hardware) and software the business uses. It also notes how important each item is and if the business owns it, leases it, or uses it as

a service.

4. **Backup Procedures:** This explains exactly how and where all the important data is copied and stored (backed up). It also details how to get that data back from the backups when needed.

5. **Disaster Recovery Procedures:** These are the immediate steps to take when a disaster happens. This includes actions to stop the problem from getting worse, making last-minute copies of data, and stopping (eradicating) threats, especially for cyberattacks.

6. **Disaster Recovery Sites:** This is about having a backup location ready to go. A 'hot disaster recovery site' is like a fully prepared backup office or data center in a different place. It has all the critical systems ready, and the data is constantly updated there, so operations can quickly switch over if the main location is affected.

7. **Restoration:** This is the final stage, detailing how to bring everything back from a complete system failure to fully working operations.

Why is a DR plan important

You might be wondering why all the effort goes into creating a Disaster Recovery Plan (DRP). Think of it like having a fire escape plan for your building. You hope you'll never need it, but if the worst happens, having that plan ready can make all the difference.

A DRP is important for several key reasons:

- **Keeping things running as smoothly as possible:** The main goal is to make sure that when a disaster strikes, your business operations don't stop completely. It's about minimizing the time things are down.
- **Teaching your team what to do:** The plan acts as a guide for your employees during an emergency. It tells them exactly what steps to take, so everyone knows their role and can react effectively.
- **Saving money:** When operations are interrupted, it costs money. A DRP helps reduce these financial losses by getting things back to normal faster.
- **Getting back to normal quickly:** The plan is designed to ensure that services can be restored smoothly and without delay once the immediate crisis has passed.
- **Having backup plans ready:** It means you've already thought about and set up alternative ways to do things if your main systems go down. This is like having a backup generator ready before the power goes out.
- **Controlling the damage:** A DRP helps to limit how bad the disruption and damage are, so a small problem doesn't turn into a complete catastrophe.

Planning a disaster recovery strategy

When businesses create a plan to get back on their feet after a disaster, they need to think about two really important goals.

Think of it like planning for a surprise party. You want to make sure everything is ready quickly, but you also don't want to lose any important memories from the past year.

- **Recovery Point Objective (RPO):** This is about how much of your recent work you can afford to lose. Imagine you're writing a novel, and a power outage happens. The RPO is like deciding how many pages (your recent work) you're okay with re-writing. It helps figure out how often you need to save your work (make backups).

- **Recovery Time Objective (RTO):** This is about how long your systems can be completely shut down before it really hurts the business. For example, if your online store goes down, you might lose money every minute it's offline. The RTO is like setting a timer for how long the store can be closed before the financial damage becomes too much. Some systems might be okay being down for an hour, while others need to be back up in just a few minutes.

Types of Disaster Recovery Sites

Imagine you have a favorite toy that you absolutely don't want to lose. A Disaster Recovery (DR) plan is like having a backup plan for your important business stuff, especially your computer systems. A key part of this plan is having a second place to keep your data safe, just in case something bad happens to your main location, like a fire or a cyber attack. This second place is called a **secondary site**.

Think of these secondary sites like different levels of preparedness for a backup location. There are three main types:

1. **Cold Computing Site:** This is the most basic backup location. It's like having an empty storage unit that has power, internet, and air conditioning, but no actual furniture or boxes inside. Before you can use it, you'd have to bring all your important things (like servers and data) and set them up. This takes a lot of time and can really slow down getting your business back up and running.

2. **Warm Computing Site:** This is a step up from a cold site. It's like that storage unit, but now it has some basic furniture and shelves already in place (like storage hardware, servers, and network equipment). It's more ready to go than a cold site, but you still need to bring your actual belongings (your data) and load them onto the existing equipment. It's partially ready, but not fully operational yet.

3. **Hot Computing Site:** This is the most advanced and ideal backup location. It's like having an exact duplicate of your main office, fully stocked and running, with all your important data already copied over and up-to-date. If something happens to your main office, you can switch over to this site almost immediately. It's the quickest to get back to business, but it's also the most expensive and complex to maintain.

Elements of Disaster Recovery Plan

So, we've talked about what a Disaster Recovery Plan (DRP) is and why it's important. Now, let's dive into the key ingredients that make up a good DRP. Think of building a DRP like preparing for a big camping trip – you need a team, you need to know what could go wrong, what gear is essential, and you need to practice using that gear.

Here are the main building blocks of a DRP:

1. **Create a disaster recovery team:** Imagine this as assembling your "emergency response crew." This team is responsible for putting the DRP together, making sure it works, and keeping it up-to-date. The plan needs to clearly list who is on the team, what each person's job is, and how to reach them. It also needs to state who to call when something bad actually happens. Everyone in the organization should know about the DRP and what their role is if a disaster strikes.

2. **Identify and assess disaster risks:** This is like scouting your campsite for potential dangers. The team needs to figure out what could go wrong, whether it's a natural event (like a flood), something caused by people (like a strike), or a technology glitch. Knowing these risks helps the team figure out what they'll need and how quickly they can get things back to normal within a timeframe that the business can handle.

3. **Determine critical applications, documents, and resources:** This means figuring out what's absolutely essential for the business to keep running, even if it's just for a short while. It's about survival – like making sure you can still get cash or make sales. For example, processing payroll is so important it usually can't wait. You need to identify these key processes, the software (applications) that run them, the important paperwork (documents), and the tools (resources) you rely on.

4. **Specify backup and off-site storage procedures:** This is like making copies of your important maps and keeping them in a safe place away from your main campsite. The plan needs to say exactly what needs to be copied (backed up), who will do it, how they'll do it, where the copies will be kept, and how often these copies should be made. This includes all those critical applications, equipment, and documents. Think about things like your latest financial reports, tax forms, a list of all your employees and how to contact them, what you have in stock (inventory records), and lists of who you do business with (customer and vendor listings). Even essential items for daily work, like blank checks or purchase orders, and a copy of the DRP itself, should be stored somewhere safe, away from your main location.

5. **Test and maintain the DRP:** Disaster planning isn't a one-time thing; it's an ongoing process because new risks pop up all the time, and businesses change. It's a good idea to regularly test the DRP to see if the steps outlined actually work and are still the right ones. The team should also update the DRP regularly to keep up with changes in how the business operates, new technology, and any new disaster risks that might have appeared.